Safeguarding in Athletics

Welcome to your UK Athletics safeguarding training.

Learning about abuse can be distressing and, for some, it may remind them of past experiences; for example, as someone who experienced abuse or as an adult who failed to act when they suspected a child was suffering abuse. If this applies to you, it may be helpful to talk to someone who is experienced in providing support; for example:

- Samaritans www.samaritans.org or telephone 116 123
- The National Association for People Abused in Childhood www.napac.org.uk or telephone 0808 801 0331
- The Survivors Trust www.thesurvivorstrust.org or telephone 0808 801 0818
- The NSPCC at www.nspcc.org.uk or call their national helpline on 0808 800 5000

Course contents

The purpose of the course is to:

- raise your awareness of abuse and neglect
- help you to recognise early signs that might indicate a problem
- show you how to take action if you know or suspect that a child, young person or adult needs help.

Module 1 – Abuse and Neglect

In this module we will cover:

- what a child needs to develop
- negative influences on a child's development
- forms of abuse
- effects of abuse.

Please note

The terminology, legislation, guidance and practice relating to child protection vary between the different nations of the UK. However, the principles are broadly the same. The course refers to 'children and young people' which includes babies, toddlers, infants, children and teenagers from birth right up to the age of 18. Throughout the course, the terminology 'child' or 'young person' is used, but the issues discussed could equally apply to adults.

Developmental needs

Whatever a child's nationality, culture or level of ability, all children broadly share the same basic developmental needs:

- emotional warmth from their parents or primary caregivers and support from the wider family
- sufficient food and clothing
- to have their health needs met
- to have an education that will provide mental stimulation.

Together, these different aspects help them as they develop through childhood and into adulthood.

The seven dimensions of a child's need

The Framework for the Assessment of Children in Need and their Families (given as a source of further information in the guidance Working Together to Safeguard Children 2015) identifies seven dimensions of child development along which children should progress if they are to realise their potential and wellbeing.
The seven dimensions of a child's needs are:

1. Health - This includes a child's growth and development as well as their physical and mental wellbeing.

2. Education - This covers all areas of a child's intellectual development which begins from birth.

3. Emotional and behavioural development - This is about a child's emotional development and how this is reflected in their behaviour as they grow. It takes into account the child's temperament, and how well they adapt to change and respond to stress.

4. Identity - This relates to the child's self-image and self-esteem and children having a positive sense of their individuality.

5. Family and social relationships - This area is about the child's increasing ability to understand and share the feelings of another.

6. Social presentation - This concerns the child's growing understanding of how their appearance, behaviour and abilities contribute to the way they are perceived by the outside world and the impression they create on others.

7. Self-care skills - These include the child's developing emotional maturity and the communication skills that will help them become independent. In the early years, they include the practical skills of washing, dressing and feeding, whereas for teenagers, they cover areas such as personal safety, sexual health and the ability to manage their own finances.

Negative influences on development

Many factors can influence a child's development, including parents' or caregivers' own ability to meet their child's needs.

Examples of these influences include:

- any experiences of physical, sexual or emotional abuse, which can have a long-lasting negative impact
- a neglectful environment – for example, you may notice a child arriving for training with poor hygiene and repeatedly unwashed kit or it is clear they have poor dental health
- separation, loss or bereavement
- social exclusion, including bullying or racism, chronic poverty and the problems associated with living in disadvantaged areas (high crime rate, poor housing etc)
- family stress caused by unemployment, financial difficulties, drug and/or alcohol misuse, mental ill health
- domestic abuse between parents or caregivers (there are also links between violence to family pets and the abuse of children)

It has been shown that even if children are unfortunate enough to experience any of these adverse influences on their development, they are more likely to be resilient in difficult conditions if they have had secure early attachments and a stable upbringing.

Forms of Abuse

In this section, we will cover:

- the different forms of abuse
- the effects of abuse
- the myths surrounding abuse.

As mentioned, we will be using the term 'child' or 'young person', but the issues covered can apply equally to adults.

What is child abuse?

Child abuse is a form of maltreatment of a child. Somebody may abuse or neglect a child by inflicting harm, or by failing to act to prevent harm. Children may be abused in a family or in an institutional, education or community setting; for example, an athletics club or other sporting venue or event. They may be abused by those known to them or, more rarely, by others unknown to them (for example, via the internet). They may be abused by an adult or adults, or another child or children.

There are four main types of child abuse. Child abuse can be physical, sexual or emotional. It can also take the form of neglectful behaviour towards a child.

Child abuse can and does happen to children from any background, culture, class, ethnicity or faith.

Physical abuse

Physical abuse may involve:

- hitting
- shaking
- throwing
- drowning
- burning or scalding
- poisoning
- suffocating
- otherwise causing physical harm to a child.

In an athletic context, physical abuse may also occur when training loads are too high or when a child or adult is encouraged to train well beyond their physical endurance.

Sexual abuse

Sexual abuse involves someone forcing or enticing someone to take part in sexual activities, not necessarily involving a high level of violence, whether or not they are aware of what is happening.

In fact, the majority of children who are sexually abused by a carer will have no visible signs at all, due to the attacker not wanting to leave evidence, amongst many other reasons in the grooming process.

Sexual abuse is not solely perpetrated by adult males. Though less common, women can also commit acts of sexual abuse, as can other children.

The activities may involve physical contact, including:

- assault by penetration
- non-penetrative acts such as masturbation, kissing, rubbing, touching outside of clothing or administering a massage.

It may also include non-contact activities, such as:

- watching sexual activities
- encouraging people to behave in sexually inappropriate ways
- involving children in looking at, or in the production of, sexual images
- grooming a child, young person or adult in preparation for abuse (including via the internet)
- filming people without their knowledge or consent.

Emotional abuse

Emotional abuse is the persistent emotional maltreatment of a child or young person such as to cause severe adverse effects on the child's health and emotional development.
Some level of emotional abuse is involved in all types of maltreatment of a child, though it may also occur alone.

Emotional abuse may involve:

- rejecting or ignoring a child completely
- using degrading language or behaviours towards them; for example, belittling their attempts to improve their performance or telling them they are 'rubbish'
- responding to their attempts to interact with emotional detachment
- making fun of them; for example, laughing at their appearance or athletic endeavours
- threatening them or encouraging them to develop behaviours that are self-destructive; for example, encouraging a person to go on a highly restricted diet or telling someone that they are not succeeding because they are under/overweight
- preventing the child from interacting socially with other children or adults
- a child seeing or hearing the ill treatment or serious bullying (including cyberbullying) of another
- causing children to feel frequently frightened or in danger
- the exploitation or corruption of children.

Emotional abuse also includes radicalising a child or young person who may be subsequently drawn into terrorist-related activity.

Neglect

Neglect is the persistent failure to meet a child's basic physical and/or psychological needs, likely to result in the serious impairment of the child's health or development. Neglect may occur during pregnancy as a result of maternal substance misuse.

Neglect may involve a coach failing to:

- provide adequate food, clothing or shelter
- protect a child from physical and emotional harm or danger
- ensure adequate supervision
- ensure access to appropriate medical care or treatment
- respond to a child's basic emotional needs
- ensure the appropriate clothing is worn for the weather conditions
- ensure training is undertaken in an appropriate location; when, for example, training during the winter season
- provide appropriate training equipment.

Female genital mutilation (FGM)

This involves procedures that include the partial or total removal of the external female genital organs for cultural or other non-therapeutic reasons. The practice is medically unnecessary, extremely painful and has serious consequences, both at the time the mutilation is carried out and in later life.

Although we have included this here, FGM is emotional and sexual abuse as well as physical abuse and is illegal in all four nations of the UK.

Child sexual exploitation

Child sexual exploitation is illegal activity by people who have power over children and young people and use it to sexually abuse them. This can include seemingly consensual relationships or sexual activity in exchange for attention, a place to stay, gifts, money, cigarettes or illegal substances. It can also include serious organised crime.

Domestic abuse

Where domestic abuse is concerned, it is thought that official figures are likely to underestimate the level of it in the UK, especially the level of emotionally abusive behaviour that is not necessarily accompanied by physical violence, but nevertheless has a significant effect on children. There is a proven link between domestic abuse and the abuse of children.

Forced marriage

In forced marriage, one or both spouses do not or cannot consent to the marriage and duress is involved. This can include physical, sexual, financial and emotional pressure. If families have to resort to violence or emotional abuse to make someone marry, the person has not given consent freely and therefore it is a forced marriage.
Forced marriage is different to an arranged marriage, where the families of both prospective spouses take a leading role in arranging the marriage, but the choice of whether or not to accept the arrangement rests with both the people involved.

Online challenges and risks

Computers, tablets and smartphones give everyone access to a wealth of information and opportunities for communication but they also bring challenges and risks, particularly when they don't know enough about keeping themselves safe.

Children, young people and adults can be put at risk of:

- seeing inappropriate images
- being the victim of online bullying (also known as cyberbullying)
- being contacted and manipulated for sexual purposes (also known as grooming)
- sharing personal and identifying information with strangers
- sending or receiving sexually explicit films, images or messages of themselves or others (this is known as sexting when sent by mobile phone).

For example, athletics clubs and coaches often have their own Facebook or WhatsApp group that could unwittingly facilitate risky behaviours.

Refer to your home country association to learn more about social media guidance.

The effects of child abuse

All abuse can have serious and potentially devastating long-lasting effects. Some people mistakenly think that if abuse is not violent or sexual in nature, it is not as bad. However, emotional abuse and neglect can be just as damaging and because they can be difficult to identify, other people are less likely to intervene.

Abuse affects children deeply as they grow up and the feelings of being 'useless', 'worthless' or 'damaged goods' are often carried over into adult life.

Children who have experienced abuse and adults who have been abused in childhood may suffer from problems around:

- behaviour
- education
- mental health
- relationships
- substance misuse (drugs and alcohol) and self-harm
- physical brain development leading to a host of serious problems as children grow (caused by neglect).

In terms of sexual abuse, research suggests that up to 50% of sexually abused children meet the full criteria for a post-traumatic stress disorder diagnosis but as many as 80% experience at least some 'post-traumatic' symptoms. These symptoms include hyper-vigilance, intrusive thoughts and sudden intrusive flashbacks of the abuse experience.

Activity

Most abuse is perpetrated by strangers.

False. In the vast majority of cases an abuser is someone known and trusted by the child. Many organisations concentrate on stranger abuse when it only accounts for 3-5% of all abuse.

Most children would tell someone if they were being sexually abused.

False. In the case of sexual abuse, sex offenders typically make the child believe that it was their (the child's) behaviour that caused them (the abuser) to act inappropriately. They do their utmost to convince the child that they (the child) are the guilty party, and as a result children frequently blame themselves for what happened and stay silent. It is also not uncommon for the perpetrator to convince the child that no one will believe them if they did speak up, or to guarantee their silence by the use of threats.

It is not just men that abuse children.

True. Professor Kevin Browne, who has been researching the maltreatment of children for 30 years, says between 5-10% of abuse against pre-pubescent children in the UK is committed by females, but only about 5% is thought to involve a woman acting alone. Many women have never been caught because they tend not to be suspected in the first place.

Children with disabilities are less likely to be abused than other children.

False. Research suggests that children with disabilities are more than three times more likely to be abused than other children.

In summary

In this module, you have learned what child abuse is and the different types of abuse. You have also learned about some of the effects it can have on a child.

There are many kinds of support available to children or adults who have experienced abuse once it has been disclosed or identified. What is important is that everyone who works with children, young people and adults understands they have a duty of care to recognise it and report it.

You are now ready to complete the corresponding Questionnaire 1.